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VISUALIZATION, HEALTH AND ADAPTABILITY

THERE ARE a few bowlers out there who have bothered me chronically. They have rubbed me the wrong way. They have caused discomfort and anxiety. Glenn McGrath. Courtney Walsh. Curtly Ambrose. New-ball assassins, all of them. They knew what they were doing. They had a relationship with the new ball, like it worked for them. They could make it talk, sing, scream, even hurt. Yes, as I faced them in my younger days, maybe the fear factor was compounded. But even though we are all retired, I would be a little unhappy facing them even today. They are my bogeymen.

But here's a secret. If you're battling fears, the visualization technique works. I never did enough of it, although I wish I had.

I started it on my own in school. But it was Wasim Akram who actually made me a believer in this great habit. It was somewhere in the beginning of my career and towards the end of his. I'm not exactly sure when exactly, but it was the sultan of swing who really got me going on something I had only experimented with at the school level.

Here's how it works. The night before a big match, just when you have hit the sack and are getting ready to pass out, think about your game in clear visual images.

Picture yourself in total, grisly detail. Lacing your boots up. Strapping your pads on. Putting your gloves on. Adjusting your helmet. Loosening your batting arm. Entering the stadium. Walking to the pitch. Taking your stance.

Play the ball, the first one, in your head. Stop it. Or flash hard, depending on who you are – though you should try not to ever flash at the first ball, ever, unless you're desperate. Or a Pathan.

Keep playing, ball by ball, in your head. Play the whole damn match in your head, if you can stay awake. Try everything. Strokeplay. Defensive stuff. Aggression. Running. Rotating the strike. Breathing. Timing the ball. Do what you must. Do what you will. Visualize it all till you pass out.